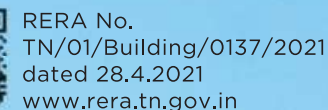


Washermenpet » Tondiarpet » Manali » M.R.C.Nagar » Teynampet » Mount Road » Broadway » Kondithope » Tiruvotiyur



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STRATOS

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Resident volunteers seen with staff; a section of Poes Road and (below) Rajakrishna Road. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Swachh Poes: baby steps to a clean and green neighbourhood

Residents of Aashiana Apartments nudge their neighbours from Poes Road and Rajakrishna Road to practise source segregation of waste

ANITA HEGDE

In 2019, a group of residents from Aashiana Apartments at Venus Colony in Alwarpet started Swachh Poes to educate households and businesses in Poes Road and Rajakrishna Road about source segregation and make this “neglected” neighbourhood a model area.

We started with door-to-door visits to spread awareness among our neighbours, which included not just apartment owners but small businesses and vendors, seeking their cooperation. We had divided ourselves into smaller groups to spread the word from Poes Road behind Aashiana to Rajakrishna Street near Eldams Road. Many were enthusiastic and optimistic. Some were disinterested. Around that time Greater Chennai Corporation had hired an outgoing waste management company to clear segregated waste which did not see the desired result.

We soldiered on with our efforts to sensitise people to the importance of segregating waste and counselled them on how to adopt environmentally responsible meth-

ods of household waste disposal.

Post-pandemic, a couple of us from Aashiana resumed our mission that had been left incomplete due to the difficult times. We connected with the officials of the new agency, the GCC, and our local councillor.

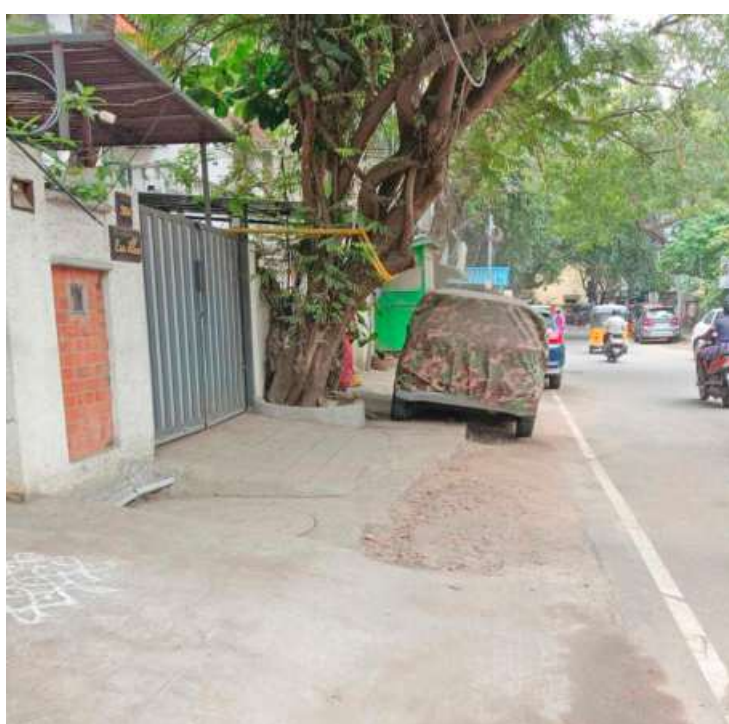
The challenges being faced are still many, given that the Poes Road-Rajakrishna Street stretch is long, connected to densely populated areas and is easily accessible to many. At times, it is utter chaos.

In the meantime, we have been finding satisfaction taking up other issues in these areas.

Supporting an anganwadi

One morning, we took a look at an anganwadi that had 30 toddlers. We learnt they had a few small requirements, towards which many Aashianites contributed gladly. We also made the authorities aware that a speed breaker was needed near the anganwadi for the safety of the children, and to maintain its surroundings properly.

Currently, Mano Vijaykumar, Ganga Sankar and I, all residents of Aashiana, go around on a daily basis, take turns to call various offi-



cials on issues ranging from tree pruning, garbage clearance, illegally dumped debris, pavements requiring repairs, encroachments taking up a large stretch of the road and parked junk cars causing un-

sanitary conditions.

The young officials of the current waste management agency deserve praise. They respond to requests and address complaints promptly.



When we feel discouraged at times, I connect with people in other parts of Chennai who have succeeded in achieving and maintaining a clean, green environment outside their gates. Encouraging and motivating conversations with them rejuvenate us. Our agenda is to involve more residents of Rajakrishna Street and Poes Road and transform our efforts into a movement; we have succeeded to some extent but we still have a long way to go.

When people say there are improvements, it makes our day.

(Anita Hegde is a resident of Aashiana Apartments and a Green Club volunteer)

MYLAPORE

Mandaveli » R A Puram » Royapettah » Chindatripet » Royapuram » Korukkupet » Ennore » Luz » Alwarpet » Triplicane » Central
Washermenpet » Tondiarpet » Manali » M.R.C.Nagar » Teynampet » Mount Road » Broadway » Kondithope » Tiruvotiyur

The Marina beach has a culture of sculpted art; by its design and focus, this one is hugely different from the other works adorning the leisure spot

M. SRINATH

The Marina beach is known for its works of sculpture, sporting an impressive array of them in spaces that passersby cannot miss even with their eyes closed. There is now an addition to this culture of sculpted art at the beach, and this one is massively different, not just in its design but also in its focus. It is a commentary on what education can do for individuals and communities and nations.

In a design that spirals into the sky, books are displayed,



PHOTO: SRINATH M

A new selfie point at the Marina?

and they are kept open, as if they had been plucked out of reading sessions.

The books being placed on a twisting column lends the artwork a sense of motion, when viewed from a physical lens, and

one of mobility, when seen from the perspective of societal development.

Under the picture of erudition are huge-sized sculpted figures of people from various stations and age groups,

underlining the universality of education. The group of people also seem to signify collective effort; and literacy from the perspective of a community, city, state and nation.

As is to be expected, this work

executed by Greater Chennai Corporation has the partnership of the Education Department.

There are selfie points at the Marina; and this one can be an massive addition to them, its off-beat design being a big draw.



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A former Corporation Commissioner's name lives on, in different forms

Nearly 10 years since historian V. Sriram pointed out that two road name boards would cause Sir Eric Conran-Smith to turn in his grave, those twin errors persist



Two name boards that maul Sir Eric Conran-Smith's name; and the statue at Ripon buildings that does justice to his memory and more importantly, his name. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK AND R. RAGU

PRINCE FREDERICK

There is honest error. And there is something called persisting in an honest error either out of ignorance or maverick indifference. One assumes, and fervently hopes, ignorance is the reason Sir Eric Conran-Smith is assuming a *nom de guerre* at the drop of a quintessentially British bowler hat.

On a Greater Chennai Corporation name board for a famous road in Gopalapuram, he goes under "Conron Smith". If disguise is the objective, that is a weak attempt at it. A few paces into this road and a

turn later, he gets better at the game, morphing into Kandran Smith, a name board for a lane off Conran Smith Road hilariously carrying 'Kandran Smith Lane'.

The images of these two name boards were clicked as recently as February 27, 2026 (and at the time of this article going to press on March 7, 2026 these name boards continued unchanged). And nearly ten years before this "photo shoot", in the column Hidden Histories in *The Hindu* (September 23, 2016), historian V. Sriram had drawn attention to how a worthy's name is being taken in vain, twice and within the distance of a few

hundred metres. And this worthy is not just any worthy. In the column, Sriram points out, surely his tongue wedged in cheek while his surprised fingers were jabbing at the keyboard, Sir Eric Conran-Smith served as Commissioner of the Corporation of Madras; the city had been this Briton's stomping ground. Sriram twists the knife by adding that the statue of this worthy adorns a prominent section of Ripon Buildings, GCC's headquarters, which does justice to his memory and more thankfully, to his name. Those snippets of information upgrades Sir Eric Conran-Smith to Worthy Plus, and the



shoddy name board job from an error to a grave error.

Here we are, in 2026, in the unfortunate position of having to point out those twin errors yet again.

While British worthies are losing name boards to Indian heroes in a

road-renaming frenzy, their wigs twirling in disappointment, Sir Eric Conran-Smith must be hoping and praying diligently from his well-appointed Elysian apartment that he lose these name boards in a city whose care was once entrusted with him.

Camp for women artists

Three city-based artists are coordinating this event, taking place at the Gallery of Contemporary Art in Egmore Museum today

The Department of Museums is organising an artists camp for women on March 7 and 8 at the Gallery of Contemporary Art in Egmore.

More than 70 women artists from across Tamil Nadu will be participating in this special event, a majority being from Chennai. On March 7, there will be a live painting session and on March 8, the completed artworks will be exhibited at the gallery in celebration of

International Women's Day.

The idea behind this camp was put forward by three Chennai-based artists Sathya N. Prabhu, Charanya Rajesh and Gayathri Balaji. "We initially planned to celebrate International Women's Day with a spot painting event and exhibition. When we approached the museum, we were surprised by the enthusiastic support extended by the Department of Museums" says Charanya. The event will see bud-

ding and aspiring artists, some juggling full-time jobs, working on different mediums and networking with each other.

This initiative aims to provide a meaningful platform for showcasing the talent of women artists and promoting art and creativity.

The event encourages women, especially homemakers, to come and see the works and interact with artists to see how this can be taken up as a profession.

Have you invited a **Madras Mali** to your garden?

They grow gardens in other people's backyards but the blooms extend into their living rooms. On International Women's Day, a conversation with Madras Malis, who are underprivileged women trained in organic gardening practices by a unique empowerment programme designed by Chennai Resilience Centre



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Many had spent years as homemakers with little opportunity for paid work. Today, as part of the Madras Malis initiative, they travel across neighbourhoods helping households establish and maintain organic kitchen gardens.

The programme traces its roots to the Chennai Resilience Centre's Chennai Urban Farming Initiative, launched in 2021 to promote organic edible gardening in urban spaces. The idea was simple: encourage residents to grow food at home, both as a source of nutrition and as a way to create greener, climate-resilient neighbourhoods where plants help reduce urban heat. Workshops and training sessions were organised with residents, teachers and community groups across the city. But as participation grew, organisers began noticing a recurring challenge. While many residents were eager to start kitchen gardens, sustaining them required technical knowledge most did not possess.

"Residents often told us that even after attending workshops, maintaining a garden was still difficult," says Ayesha Ajmal, Junior Re-

search Associate and Communications Manager at the Chennai Resilience Centre, who coordinates Mali assignments, manages social media, and assists with training sessions. "There were challenges with pests, soil health and identifying the right inputs to use."

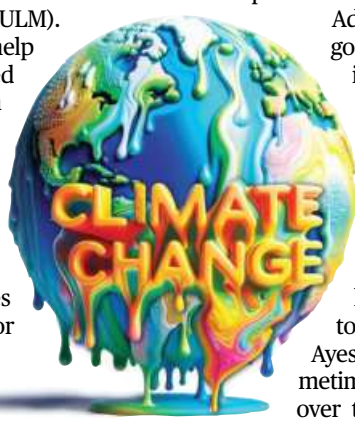
Organisers also recognised another gap. While gardeners were available in the city, most focused on routine tasks such as watering or pruning. Few had the expertise to maintain edible gardens using organic techniques or diagnose plant health problems.

To address this, while also creating livelihood opportunities, the initiative began collaborating with the Tamil Nadu Urban Livelihoods Mission (TNULM). Women from self-help groups were invited to participate in specialised gardening training. This effort gradually evolved into the Madras Mali programme. Ayesha underlines that eligibility for participating in the training

programme is predicated on a woman's membership in a self-help group registered under TNULM.

Between 2022 and 2024, the initiative operated as a pilot under the Urban Thottam project, experimenting with training formats while connecting trained women with households seeking help. By 2025, the programme was formally structured and launched under the name Madras Mali, with a dedicated website, social media presence and a defined list of services. Since 2023, nearly 250 women have received training. The training is designed in stages. Participants begin with fundamentals – soil preparation, plant varieties and common pests.

Advanced sessions go deeper into pruning, identifying fungal infections and diagnosing nutrient deficiencies. "These sessions are usually conducted in modules lasting around two to three hours," Ayesha explains. "Sometimes they take place over two or three days



M. Krishnaveni (wearing a hat) from Chintadripet talks to a client about a plant; V. Prabha from R.A. Puram and B. Geetha from Taramani, also at work in their respective client's garden. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

their confidence. B. Geetha from Taramani says the work has given her a sense of financial independence. "Earlier, I depended on my husband even for small things. If my children asked for a pencil or a book, I had to ask him for money. Now I can manage these small expenses myself." Appreciation from residents keeps her motivated too. "Residents sometimes send photos of the harvest. Seeing that makes me feel very satisfied." Others say the programme has expanded their world beyond their immediate neighbourhoods.

V. Prabha from R.A. Puram, who has been working as a Mali for three years, says the experience has made her more confident. "Earlier I hardly stepped outside my area. Now I know some bus routes and I can interact with more people." Gardening has also become a passion. "I keep encouraging people around me to grow more plants at home."

Their work has extended beyond private homes to schools and community institutions, including a Greater Chennai Corporation High School at Kamaraj Avenue in Adyar, the Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust in Teynampet, Little Flower Nursery and Primary School in Adambakkam and Government Higher Secondary School in Sholinganallur. Students are often involved in sowing and harvesting, turning gardens into learning spaces, with vegetables sometimes used in the institutions' kitchens. "Seeing them eat the greens they harvest for lunch feels more fulfilling than the money," says one of the Madras Malis, M. Krishnaveni from Chintadripet.

The challenges

Like many livelihood initiatives, the programme comes with challenges. Working through Chennai's summers can be gruelling, and the work occasionally involves physically demanding tasks such as carrying heavy pots. Managing client expectations has also required attention; organisers now address this by clearly explaining the scope of work to both parties before assignments begin.

Despite these challenges, the initiative continues to grow largely through word of mouth. Many clients who first hear about the service through friends or neighbours eventually become repeat users. Those interested in availing the Madras Mali service can contact the team via WhatsApp at 9176588007. More details are available at urbanthottam.com/madras-mali-veg-garden-kit/ and @urbanthottam on Instagram.



depending on the women's availability."

Beyond classroom sessions, participants are also exposed to organic farming at scale. In late 2023, a group attended a residential programme at a farm run by the Centre for Indian Knowledge Systems near Vedanthangal, where they explored traditional vegetable varieties, visited rice fields and participated in organic farming demonstrations.

The programme also emphasises entrepreneurial skills. Participants learn to prepare organic pesticides and plant growth promoters using locally available ingredients, which they can market to clients. They are also trained to set up composting systems and guide households in converting kitchen waste into compost. For the Malis, minimum payment is fixed at ₹850 for five hours; the Malis receive the payment directly from the clients and Chennai Resilience Centre does not receive a commission.

A confidence boost

For many participants, the most visible transformation has been in



Participants at a solar rooftop installation competition.

What they say

'We have asked vendors in Chennai to focus on gated communities'

A lot more needs to be done to increase awareness among consumers. In Chennai, there are many apartment complexes and gated communities, so we have asked our members to focus on resident welfare associations as some are of the impression that the PM Surya Ghar scheme is not applicable to them. Power consumption in the common areas at gated communities is huge and by installing solar photovoltaic systems in the common areas, the benefit is extended to every resident. The space is uniformly distributed among residents and there will be reduction in the maintenance bill.

L. R. Venkatesh, secretary, Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association

'Solar panels at electronic stores!'

Last year, Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group (CAG) conducted at least 50 meetings, both for gated communities and other stakeholder. This year, we are working towards covering more ground. For example, we want to bring banks, TNGECL, solar developers and RWAs on one platform that will promote adoption of rooftop solar systems. We are also working on skilling and upskilling programmes in solar energy adoption for those in the allied skill pool such as electricians and architects, and also exploring how rooftop solar panels can find space on the shelves of electronic stores by working with electrical and electronics retailers.

K. Vishnu Mohan Rao, Programme Lead, CAG

'Create awareness about maintenance of panels'

As a prosumer for more than two years now, one lesson learnt is not to ignore the need to maintain solar panels. The quality and quantity of energy produced can decrease significantly if not maintained. I had not discussed maintenance with my vendor when I invested in a solar rooftop system and neither was I aware that AMC contract is available. The vendor too did not guide me. Now, twice a year I reach out to other technicians/service providers to get this work.

Logendrakumar M.K., president, Chettinad Enclave Village Owners Association, Pallikaranai

Where does the sun shine the brightest?

In Tamil Nadu, Chennai secures the second slot in terms of adoption of solar energy through rooftop installations. Coimbatore tops the table. Chengalpattu is in the third position

LIFFY THOMAS

On February 23, 2026, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on X praised India's rooftop solar adoption that has powered 30 lakh households since the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana was launched two years ago. A remarkable milestone in India's clean energy transition. The question closer home would be: two years on, where does Tamil Nadu stand?

According to data shared by Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation Limited, 55,328 households have installed rooftop photovoltaic solar power systems in Tamil Nadu until February 28, 2026.

Tamil Nadu is in the 11 position, with states such as Gujarat, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh ahead of it. For rankings, an official says, one should refer the number of installation on the PM Surya Ghar portal, which is total number of individual installation plus the number of installa-

tions done by flats (RWA).

In Tamil Nadu, Coimbatore leads among the districts for completing the maximum number of installations, followed by Chennai (see box).

Those working in the industry say the State's journey has been slow but steady, and a lot more ground needs to be covered. This includes enlisting more qualified vendors, increasing awareness among consumers, setting measurable, time-bound targets and guiding prosumers (those who produce and consume) who face challenges after installing rooftop solar (RTS) systems.

"Both the central government and state governments have jurisdiction over electricity. Initially, there were bottlenecks in synchronising details of electricity department with the PM Surya Ghar portal, which were ironed out," says L.R. Venkatesh, secretary, Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association (TNSEDA).

In the first year, many new consumers complained of delayed pay-

The top five districts

- Coimbatore: 8,107
- Chennai: 6,550
- Chengalpattu: 4,441
- Salem: 3,067
- Erode: 2,985

* This data pertains to number of installations until December 2025

ment and long processing time which has drastically reduced in the last one year. Short supply of domestic panels also derailed the installation process.

Currently, a total of 1,376 registered vendors are enlisted on the PM Surya Ghar portal.

"From less than 200 vendors, we now have more than 1,000," says Venkatesh, who is managing director Vesat Renewables.

The implementing agencies have started to take vendors to task. "Very often we see inspections happening randomly, which

is good to establish quality in the system. Vendors are being asked to follow all procedures or they can be blacklisted. We are conducting training programmes for listed vendors so that they can upskill themselves with the latest in the renewable energy sector," says Venkatesh.

Implementing agencies

Tamil Nadu Green Energy Corporation Limited along with Rural Electrification Corporation has been working with vendors to iron out wrinkles in the system.

A senior official says two initiatives that has taken solar rooftop to this stage is the monthly meetings they host among vendors to clarify nagging doubts. The Corporation has also set aside targets, district-wise, with the section officer being held responsible for ensuring a minimum stipulated number of installations for the area. Based on the criterion of meeting targets (which vary from district to district), Chengalpattu was declared as the top-performing district.

The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy aims to install 30GW of rooftop solar capacity by 2027 and a lot more needs to be done.

A report brought out by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) in April 2025 on 'How are Indian States Enabling Rooftop Solar Adoption?' suggests setting clear, time-bound targets to establish the state's vision for rooftop solar, mandate solarisation of government buildings, standardise the installation process, create the right economic incentives for consumers, and create a rooftop solar data registry.

Bicycles distributed at event in Royapettah

Rotary International District 3234 organised the “Gift of Mobility” project, distributing bicycles to 425 school going girls and boys at Amir Mahal Ground in Royapettah.

The project was supported by Meridian Global Ventures Pvt Ltd under its CSR grant. The initiative is designed to ease the daily commute of students to school, reduce drop out rates, and encourage continued education, particularly among children from underserved communities, said a release.

The programme was led by District Governor Rtn.Vinod Saraogi (2025-26), who highlighted Rotary’s commitment to educational empowerment and community upliftment.

Chief Guest Er Muruganandam, RI vice president (2026-27) and RI director (2025-27); guest of honour Nawabzada Mohammed Asif Ali, Dewan to the Prince of Arcot; Ravi Sundaresan, District Governor (2028-29),



along with Rotary leaders and members from across the district took part.

Club Presidents supporting the

initiative included Baskaran (RC Madras Pallava), Bala Karthik S (RC Madras Besant Nagar), Mohamed Kamal (RC Madras Silver

Beach), Ravikumar K S (RC Chennai Mugappair), and Nabin Prasad Yadav (RC Chennai Nandanam), added the release.

A fund raiser for those with special needs

Chettinad-Sarvalokaa Education International School in Kelambakkam recently organised a student-led walkathon, which was conceptualised and led by students of grade VIII.

Held at the Health City campus, surrounded by lush greenery, the walkathon offered participants an opportunity to support a cause while promoting health and well-being, said a release.

The students raised funds for Sri Arunodayam Charitable Trust, an organisation that empowers individuals with special needs. The funds raised will contribute to the trust’s ongoing work in providing essential care, resources, and opportunities for those they serve, added the release.

The initiative is part of the service learning project of the students, where they demonstrated leadership, empathy, and a strong sense of purpose, the release added.

Reunion of 1969 batch of school in Triplicane



Dr. P. Sasikumar was the special guest at the school; and old students at the meet

The 173rd Annual Day of Hindu Higher Secondary School was a grand celebration of academic excellence, cultural heritage, and student achievements. Held at the school, the venue was beautifully adorned with colourful backdrops, intricate rangoli designs.

Guest of honour Dr. P. Sasikumar, Dean and Professor of Surgery at Balaji Medical College and Hospital, Chrompet, graced the occasion.

Also present were school secretary M.O. Ram Manoj; HEO members S. Sadagopan, Member of GST Council and Kamalakannan, professor of Zoology. Alumni Secretary K. Murugan, Alumni

Joint Secretary T. Anand, and EC Member Sundar Subba Rao also took part.

Dr. P. Sasikumar gave a motivational speech, reminiscing about his school days and urging students to embrace challenges early in life for greater success.

Meritorious students received prizes. Awards were also presented to retired teachers and the best teachers of the year.

Alumni meet

Forty three students of 1969 batch of Hindu High School, Triplicane met at Alumni Club for the annual celebration on February 28.

Subrahmanian, architect, Thanupa Santosh (Human Resources), Urvashi Deshpande, interior designer, Preetha Raghav (global facilitator and leadership catalyst), Suramanjari Elangovan, entrepreneur (Fintech), Malar Vikram, costume designer, and Darsani for sports.

On the occasion, the lifetime achievement award was given to veteran actress Rajyalakshmi, honouring her lasting legacy and decades of contributions to Indian cinema and television, the release added.

Celebrating their strength, resilience

The ninth edition of Realistic Awards was held recently in the city. A social initiative by Pakwan Chennai, SPICA Modular Solutions Limited, Realistic Awards honours women who lead, inspire and redefine excellence in their respective fields.

This year, 20 women from diverse fields were recognised for their passion, perseverance and groundbreaking contributions.

They are Rachitha Mahalakshmi (small screen), Shrinidhi, a radio jockey, Anitha Guha, classical dancer, Lavanya, classical singer, Rakshita Suresh, playback singer, Vagu Mazan, independent artist, Akshatha Das, video jockey, G Kavya, choreographer, Meenu Balaji, a nutritionist and dietician, Dr Vasundra Thiagarajan, doctor, Salomi Rinita, a make-up artist, Padmini Ravichandran, journalist, Krithika

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A 'ballerina' shows up at Nemmeli Salt Pans

This is the first sighting of the Demoiselle Crane anywhere in the Chennai Metropolitan Area. Naman Bora and Amogh Chatty found the vagrant bird feeding in the reeds at the salterns on February 28



A vagrant Demoiselle Crane at Nemmeli Salt Pans photographed by Naman Bora on March 1 and (left) by Amogh Chatty on February 28.

The truth in fact runs deeper, the bird's name and its significance preceding the book.

Why harp on Marie Antoinette and the Demoiselle Crane now? Here is answering this question nagging the reader. On the evening of February 28, 2026, two youngsters from Chennai were treated to a ballet performance by the "mademoiselle" at the Nemmeli salt pans. Naman Bora, a sophomore-student at VIT on Kelambakkam-Vandalur High Road and Amogh Chatty, a Class X student of PSSBB Millennium at Semmancherry, both members of Madras Naturalists Society (MNS) sighted and photographed a lone vagrant Demoiselle Crane (*Grus virgo*) while it was feeding among the reeds and while it was in flight.

The record of the sighting is up on eBird; and it is the first documented sighting of the bird in Chennai.

Gnanaskandan Kesavabharathi, a senior reviewer at eBird, confirms it and places this individual bird in its life stage based on its features: "It is a sub-adult bird considering the white near throat and forehead, short white ear tufts and the brownish orange iris versus a

reddish iris in full adults."

That this bird is a lone vagrant and no "relative" was keeping lockstep with its peregrinations into uncharted territory was confirmed the following morning. Naman observes that on Sunday morning (March 1) he went with wildlife photographer Sudharshan Kuselan to the Nemmeli salt pans and the duo found the Demoiselle Crane around the same spot. Naman displayed greater tenacity, returning to the spot for another two days (March 2 and 3) and found the bird matching his tenacity. Naman observes that the bird was tenaciously clinging on to its feeding spot in the reeds, being found within 100 metres of the spot it was first seen at. "After roosting, it would return to this feeding spot," Naman adds. Gnanaskandan notes two earlier records of Demoiselle Crane sighting for Tamil Nadu exist. Both have come from Vijaynarayanam Tank in Tirunelveli: two birds sighted in 2006, and one in 2007.

Weighing in on this sighting at Nemmeli, ornithologist V. Shantaram places it in perspective: "A majority of Demoiselle Crane sightings are from western India, specifically Gujarat and Rajasthan. At Khichan Village in Rajasthan, sighting a flock of 4,000-5,000 Demoiselle Cranes is not uncommon. Those are the places they normally visit, but they do move around. These birds are great wanderers. I mean they come from Central Asia and fly down to Gujarat and for them to come down south is not a big thing, but they do not have to unless there is a drought or there is some other reason for their movement. It could be one of those reasons, or just that some of the birds are more adventurous. There are a lot of possibilities; they probably come in here regularly in small numbers (during winter) and we have missed them out."

PRINCE FREDERICK

Marie Antoinette's image has been shaped by words not her own, but consistently put in her mouth through the centuries. Two things she did not say continue to be misattributed to her. One, the suggestion that the poor French peasants could have cakes if they lacked bread. And the other, oddly, has to do with ornithology. She is believed to have given Demoiselle Crane its name impressed by its uber-feminine movements, largely dance-like. Anyone in India faintly familiar with French having taken it up to bump up the aggregate in their higher secondary board exams, as this writer did decades ago, would realise Demoiselle is from French and a variant of Mademoiselle, denoting a young lady. Back to Marie and her putative bird-christening abilities, this bird was given that name for its ultra-feminine demeanour but not by her. Here is why.

The infamous French queen was born in 1755, and an account of why the bird goes under the name Demoiselle Crane is found, with an illustration, in George Edwards's *A Natural History of Uncommon Birds*, its various volumes written between 1743 and 1751. Even if the account about the Demoiselle Crane spilt out of the quilt-pen in 1751, it is a good four years before Marie arrived. The book is in the public domain, accessible at Biodiversity Heritage library (biodiversitylibrary.org).

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